

Then came the most testing phase of all.

In August 2019, following the abrogation of Article 370, the entire region went into lockdown. At the time, we had ongoing camps in Srinagar for both senior and age-group teams. It was a large contingent of players and support staff. We managed to leave just before August 5, but uncertainty loomed.

With the region shut, we had no clarity on when or where training could resume. The boys were anxious, and momentum was at risk. At that moment, I reached out to Samarjit Singh Gaekwad, the current titular head of the Gaekwad dynasty of Baroda. His generosity was extraordinary. He allowed us to train at the Motibaug ground in Vadodara.

That decision proved crucial.

The red-soil surface in Vadodara was a new experience for many of our players. Back home, they were largely used to black soil, which behaves differently — lower bounce and less pronounced turn. On red soil, there is sharper bounce and more grip for spinners.

It challenged their technique. We designed specific drills — sweep shots, reverse sweeps and back-foot play — to help them adapt.

We played several practice matches against Baroda and even managed to beat them in a few. Those wins, even unofficial ones, boosted confidence. They showed the boys they could compete with established teams in their own backyard.

That season, we carried that belief into the Ranji Trophy and qualified for the knockouts, eventually falling agonisingly short against Karnataka. It hurt deeply at the time. But when I later saw the boys create history by defeating the same team, my heart swelled with pride.

Looking back, the technical adjustments, scouting drives and infrastructure upgrades all mattered. But what truly changed the trajectory was empathy and fairness.

When players feel respected, when they believe selection is transparent and when they know their voices are heard, they perform differently.

The future of cricket in Jammu and Kashmir is bright. The boys are not short of talent. They are hungry for opportunity, recognition and respect. Now that they have broken psychological and structural barriers, there is no ceiling.

With continued backing and clarity of vision, they can aim even higher.

A former India international, Irfan Pathan was the mentor of the Jammu and Kashmir team from 2018 to 2020.

(As told to Shayan Acharya)



Unearthing talent: Auqib Nabi (top) and Abdul Samad, two of the young cricketers identified during Irfan Pathan's talent hunts across Jammu and Kashmir, have gone on to become key symbols of the region's emerging cricketing depth. R. V. MOORTHY & K. MURALI KUMAR